

## Reading Practice 02

### The Marshmallow Test

In the late 1960s and early 1970s, psychologist Walter Mischel and other researchers studied how young children responded when they had to wait for something they wanted. The research became widely known as the marshmallow test. Although marshmallows were sometimes used, children could also choose another treat, such as a cookie or a pretzel. The experiment was designed to study delayed **gratification**, or the ability to wait for a better reward instead of choosing a smaller reward immediately.

During the experiment, a child sat in a room with one treat placed nearby. A researcher explained that the child could eat the treat immediately. However, if the child waited until the researcher returned, the child would receive two treats. The researcher then left the room for several minutes. Some children ate the treat quickly, while others managed to wait.

The children who waited did not simply stare at the treat and depend on willpower. Many created ways to distract themselves. Some covered their eyes, turned away, sang songs, played with their hands, or imagined that the treat was something that could not be eaten. **These strategies** reduced their attention to the reward and made waiting easier. The experiment therefore suggested that self-control may depend partly on how people direct their thoughts.

Years later, researchers contacted some of the original participants. Early follow-up studies found a relationship between longer waiting times and certain positive results later in life, such as stronger academic performance. This led many people to believe that the test could reveal a child's future level of success. **However, a relationship between two things does not necessarily mean that one directly causes the other.**

Later researchers examined the test more carefully. They found that a child's environment may also influence the decision to wait. For example, children may be less willing to wait when they are uncertain that an adult will return with the promised reward. Family resources and earlier experiences may also affect the choice. As a result, the marshmallow test is not a simple measurement of whether a child has "good" or "bad" self-control. Instead, **it shows that people's choices can be affected by both how they manage their thoughts and what they have learned from the past.**

1. The word **gratification** in paragraph 1 is closest in meaning to:
  - A) patience
  - B) reward
  - C) control
  - D) promise
  
2. According to **paragraph 4**, what did early follow-up studies find?
  - A) Children who waited longer often showed stronger academic performance later.
  - B) Children who chose pretzels were more successful than those who chose cookies.
  - C) Most children who waited became psychologists as adults.
  - D) Children who ate the treat quickly usually came from larger families.
  
3. **These strategies** in **paragraph 3** refers to:
  - A) extremely high temperatures
  - B) dangerous machinery
  - C) poor air quality
  - D) regular flooding inside the tunnels
  
4. Which sentence best expresses the essential information in the **highlighted sentence** from **paragraph 4**?
  - A) Two things can be connected even when neither one directly produces the other.
  - B) Researchers cannot determine whether events are connected without repeating a study.
  - C) Positive events in childhood usually lead to positive results in adulthood.
  - D) Two events that occur together must have been caused by the same experience.
  
5. What can be inferred about a child who trusted the researcher's promise?
  - A) The child will certainly be more successful as an adult.
  - B) The child may be more willing to wait because the second reward seems reliable.
  - C) The child will find it easier to ignore food than other children do.
  - D) The child probably has greater natural self-control than everyone else.
  
6. Which sentence best paraphrases the **highlighted idea** from **paragraph 5**?
  - A) Trust is the main reason people are able to control their behavior.
  - B) Past experiences matter only when people do not have a useful strategy.
  - C) Decisions are shaped by personal strategies as well as by trust and experience.
  - D) People make better choices when they ignore their experiences and depend on self-control.